

Phase 2 Report: Class Schedule Evaluator

For Phase 2, our team refined the original idea of **DecisionMate**, a broad AI-powered decision support assistant, into a more focused and practical application called the **Class Schedule Evaluator**. In the original proposal, the goal was to help users reason through decisions by generating pros and cons, summarizing tradeoffs, and offering recommendations. As we developed the project further, we realized that narrowing the scope would make the idea easier to implement, test, and demonstrate. We chose class schedule evaluation because it is a real problem that students regularly face and it still aligns closely with the original goal of helping users make better decisions.

The Class Schedule Evaluator is a simple web-based application that allows a user to enter a class schedule and receive a structured evaluation of that schedule. The user can input each class name, the number of credit hours, optional syllabus text, and optional student review summaries. Based on this information, the app estimates the weekly workload, rates the difficulty of each class, determines an overall schedule difficulty, and generates a short list of pros and cons. The screenshots in the attached PDF show both the input interface and the formatted output of the application. The first page shows the form where users add classes and supporting details, and the second page shows the final evaluation layout generated by the app.

The main logic of the application is intentionally simple and beginner-friendly. The app estimates total weekly workload by using the rule of **4 hours of work per week per credit hour**. It then assigns each class a difficulty score on a scale from 1 to 3, represented by emojis: **1 = 🟢**, **2 = 🟡**, **3 = 🔴**. These ratings are based on the expected workload suggested by the class information, syllabus text, and any student review summaries provided by the user. After that, the app adds together the ratings of all classes and converts the total into an overall schedule rating using a flame scale ranging from **very easy** to **very difficult**. Finally, it generates a short pros-and-cons list so that the user can quickly understand the strengths and weaknesses of the schedule. The sample output shown in the PDF includes total weekly time, class ratings, an overall schedule rating, and pros and cons in the exact format we designed.

AI played an important role in this phase, mainly through the use of **Codex** to help generate the front-end structure and application logic. Rather than building every part manually from scratch, we used AI-assisted coding to quickly create a working prototype that follows our specified format and functionality. This made it possible to move from a broad concept to a functioning MVP within the limited project timeline. Although the current version is not a trained custom model, it still demonstrates how AI can support decision-making by organizing information and translating it into a useful evaluation for the user.

One of the biggest lessons from Phase 2 was the importance of scope. Our original proposal was interesting, but it was too broad for an early-stage prototype. By narrowing the idea to school schedules, we created something much more concrete and realistic. Another lesson was that vague ideas such as “schedule strength” or “difficulty” need to be translated into specific

rules before they can be implemented effectively. We addressed that by defining clear scales for class ratings, workload estimation, and overall difficulty.

Overall, Phase 2 was successful because it transformed the project from an abstract idea into a working prototype. The Class Schedule Evaluator shows that our team can take the original concept of AI-supported decision-making and apply it to a focused, useful student problem. This gives us a strong foundation for future improvements, such as using more official class data, refining the difficulty logic, and eventually expanding back toward the broader DecisionMate vision.